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The Bhutanese

VOL 13 ISSUE 15 SATURDAY 20 APRIL 2024 NU 20

LEADING THE WAY

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Zhung Dratshang offers Ku-Sung-Thukten Mendrel to HH Kyabgon Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche

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3 Drug Convicts in Chamgang share how they got into drugs, the drug culture in Bhutan, the drug trade and the big fishes

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

Chamgang Jail was meant to house around 400 to 500 prisoners in five blocks, but today it has around 700 plus prisoners and over half of them at around 370 are in due to drug cases.

The Bhutanese talked to three such prisoners to gain an understanding of what led them into drugs, how they got caught and a deeper insight into the drug culture and trade in Bhutan. For privacy reasons and to ensure they can share all details the paper has changed the names of the three convicts but every other detail is accurate.

A teacher

Sonam (named changed) aged 28 from Wangdue Phodrang is the last person you would assume would get locked up in Chamgang.

A gentle looking and soft-spoken person, Sonam completed his course in NIE Paro passed RCSC and was serving as a teacher in a southern Dzongkhag

However, beneath all that Sonam came from a broken family and he had a difficult childhood.

Sonam said that addiction was in his family as his father was an alcohol addict. He said things were fine for him and he was like any normal confident kid until class one when things took a big turn as his father's alcohol problems escalated into domestic violence and aggression and his father and mother split up and got back two times until a final

cont. on pg 10 & 11

PM explains what the Nu 15 bn ESP will be used for

Stringent monitoring to ensure payback of loans

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

For some time now there has been a lot of speculation on what the Nu 15 billion (bn) Economic Stimulus Program will be used for.

The only thing known was that it would be used to stimulate the economy.

The Prime Minister Dasho Tshering Tobgay has now said the Nu 15 bn Economic Stimulus Program money will be used to lift the loan moratorium and

cont. on pg 11

Assessment for Saturday off or not finds curriculum too heavy and teachers doing too many things

Decision on Saturday expected to come within next two weeks

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

In the first week of March 2024 there was a lot of controversy as it was revealed that a Committee set up to study the Saturday off pledge had recommended not to give Saturday off.

The government at the time said it is only a committee recommendation and a final decision was not yet taken.

Subsequently it was reported by this paper that the Ministry of Education and Skills Development (MoESD) has hired an international education assessment team called 'Cambridge International,' which

cont. on pg 06

MoESD and RCSC agree to changes in IWP for teachers

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

For a while now teachers have not been happy with the bell curve resulting from the assessment or moderation of the Individual Work Plan (IWP) whereby a few have to be placed in the Partly Meeting Expectations (PME) category.

Teachers felt particularly aggrieved with the PME in the bell curve and felt it is not fair or does not capture their ground realities.

The Ministry of Education and Skills Development (MoESD) and the Royal Civil

cont. on pg 06

Editorial

The Drug Problem

Bhutan has always had a drug problem but we never truly realized its scale until His Majesty The King pointed to the urgency of the issue.

The drug problem was steadily but surely creeping into our homes, schools, workplaces, and families and it had taken quite a toll until His Majesty woke us out of our collective slumber.

There is no doubt that drugs is a national menace and we must fight it on all fronts.

Here, the first and most important place to launch a fightback is the family unit. It is noticed that the majority of drug abusers are either from broken families or their family did not supervise them enough and gave them all the money and freedom they wanted.

Families carry the most important responsibility of all as the root cause of substance abuse among people leads back to an unhappy home and trauma as a child.

Another important set up is in schools and colleges and among youths in general as many young people get into drugs due to peer pressure and its normalization.

We may not like to admit it but there is a drug culture which is also known as the 'drug life' among the youths.

It is important to communicate to the youth and let them know that drugs are not cool and that it has crushing consequences.

The third place for the fightback is in terms of deaddiction centers where Bhutan is doing a good job with many youths undergoing such programs.

The fourth place is in terms of curbing the easy supply of drugs and here the RBP has been doing a good job in cracking down on drug smuggling.

Going forward it will be important to ensure that we carry on reforming our laws and systems to adapt to an ever-changing challenge.

One such challenge is the growing congestion of our jails due to the large arrests. This is because anyone carrying about 21 SP+ tablets is considered a smuggler and gets a 5-year jail sentence.

However, in reality addicts can pop 21 pills a day or more and may be carrying it for personal use. We need to modify the law to ensure users are not imprisoned, while the real smugglers bringing in thousands of pills are punished.

Q

Just a quote

"Addiction begins with the hope that something 'out there' can instantly fill up the emptiness inside." —**Jean Kilbourne**"

DRUKYUL SPEAKS ITS MIND

The Urgency of Palestinian Statehood

By Gareth Evans

MELBOURNE – It is time for Israel to recognize the force of the rapidly growing international movement to recognize Palestinian statehood, not as the final outcome of a political settlement but as a path to achieving it. Were Israel to get serious again about pursuing a two-state solution, it would not be rewarding Hamas, but benefiting itself.

The awful reality, as the horrendous attacks of October 7, 2023, made clear, is that without a political solution that satisfies legitimate Palestinian aspirations, Israel will never be free of the specter of terrorism.

My decades of experience with conflict prevention and resolution, including years of talking to all sides in the Middle East, have drummed home the truth that despair can all too easily turn into rage, and then into indefensible outrage. By the same token, the threat of violence diminishes rapidly during those periods of genuine hope for a just and dignified settlement.

To understand the roots of October 7 is not to justify the slaughter of innocents, then or ever. Israel was undoubtedly entitled to respond with all the force that international law allows. But for Israeli Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu's government – and those who blindly support it – to remain in denial about those roots, and to offer no political way forward, is simply to invite more of the same. This is especially true now that so many ordinary, decent Palestinians have been displaced, traumatized, and angered by the disproportionate savagery of the Israeli response.

As I have argued elsewhere, the moral, legal, and political case for recognizing Palestinian statehood has always been strong. Some 140 United Nations member states – albeit nearly all of them from the Global South – have already done so. The Gaza war has now lent the issue new relevance and urgency. More and more countries see Israel's intransigence as not only perpetuating Palestinian misery but also guaranteeing its own.

Australia, in a pathbreaking speech by Foreign Minister Penny Wong on April 9, became the latest of a host of formerly cautious countries – including the United Kingdom, Ireland, Spain, Norway, and even the United States – to make clear that it is actively considering early recognition of Palestinian statehood. True, the timing is an issue. With UN votes on full membership for Palestine expected at the Security Council and in the General Assembly this month, the US and some others may not yet be willing to issue formal declarations. Nonetheless, the direction of travel is clear, and momentum is building.

Many argue, nonetheless, that recognition of Palestinian statehood is an empty, quixotic gesture. Practically, a two-state solution now looks unattainable, owing to the territorial fragmentation created by Israel's increasingly unrestrained West Bank settlement-building program. And Israeli hostility to a two-state solution, and Palestinian support for its own one-state solution, have both grown steadily and likely become more entrenched since October 7.

All true enough, but the dream of a two-state solution must be kept alive, not only because it remains overwhelmingly the preferred policy internationally, but also because it is so obviously in Israel's own long-term interest. As many commentators over the years have pointed out, Israel potentially can be a Jewish state, a democratic state, and a state occupying the whole of historical Judea and Samaria. But it cannot be all three at the same time. (This was a favorite line of my old boss, Australian Prime Minister Bob Hawke, in offering tough love to the Jewish community here.)

The argument for recognizing Palestinian statehood is that doing so is vital to restore a balance that has tipped overwhelmingly in favor of Israel. No peace negotiation can succeed if the parties at the table are completely mismatched. For the foreseeable future, the best – and possibly the only – way to counter the current mismatch is to show that Palestine has legitimacy not only in the Islamic world and the Global South, but globally, including in traditional pillars of the Global North, like the UK, Australia, and other US allies and partners.

While it is not necessary for a state to be recognized as such to have a government in effective control of its entire territory, the issue is made more complicated by governance problems on the Palestinian side. The Palestinian Authority is a gerontocracy in desperate need of reform, and Hamas has dealt itself out of any international acceptance with its military wing's terrorist excesses.

Constructing a viable pan-Palestinian government – preferably with the support of key regional players – will certainly be a long haul. I am among those who have long believed that the imprisoned Palestinian activist Marwan Barghouti – popular in both Gaza and the West Bank – could be the Mandela-likeunifierthat Palestinians desperately need. But for precisely that reason, persuading Israel to release him will be a Herculean task, at least as long as Netanyahu remains in power.

Regardless of whether the two-state solution proves to have any life left in it, conferring Palestine the extra legitimacy, leverage, and bargaining power inherent in recognized statehood would help achieve for both sides a future that is better than the awful status quo.

If it does still have life, as we must all hope, Palestinian leverage will be crucial in producing just and sustainable solutions to the big outstanding issues, including those concerning boundaries, credible security guarantees for both sides, the protection of holy sites, and the fraught question of refugee rights.

But even if the only remaining option is to negotiate a new, democratic, non-apartheid single state (in which Palestinians enjoy fully equal rights alongside Israel's Jewish population), giving Palestinians more legitimacy and heft at the bargaining table serves the goal of securing a sustainable peace.

At a time of dramatically heightened tension with Iran, and all the renewed sense of insecurity that comes with it, it has never been more important for Israel to defuse the visceral anger of Palestinians in the Occupied Territories. Most of the rest of the world is now telling Israel that the best way to start is to accept the force of Palestinians' claim to statehood. If Israelis really want a more secure future, it is time for them to listen.

Gareth Evans was Australia's foreign minister (1988-96), president of the International Crisis Group (2000-09), and chancellor of the Australian National University (2010-19).

Majority of Drug arrests were unemployed, students and private employees

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

As per Royal Bhutan Police's (RBP) statistic 2023, there were 3,669 individuals arrested, which includes 356 individuals below 18 years of age, 1,545 youths, and 1,768 adults.

Offence wise, 2,810 individuals were arrested for substance use, 759 for trafficking, 61 illegal sales of inhalants and solvents and 39 illegal possessions.

Occupation wise, 1,464 were unemployed, 470 were students, 589 were private employees, 40 were in government sectors, 40 trainees, prisoners or repeat offenders were 9, 296 drivers, 32 guides, 341 business owners, 101 farmers, 106 labors, 21 housewives and other 155.

Dzongkhag wise, it was 1,505 arrests in Thimphu, 715 in Chukha, 369 in Sarpang, 276 in Samtse, 206 in Paro, 142 in Samdrup Jongkhar, 114 in Wangdue, 76 in Dagana, 58 in Punakha, 35 in Mongar, 31 in Trashigang, 25 in Trashiyangtse, 22 in Pemagatshel, 17 in Trongsa, both Haa and Bumthang with 15 arrests and 13 in Zhemgang and 5 in Lhuentse.

Gender wise arrests were 3,441 males and 228 females.

Seizure wise, 243,849 capsules of SP Plus, 2,401 tablets of Nitrosun10, 14.97kgs of cannabis, 1.91kgs of hashes, 0.36gm of brown sugar, 0.006kg of ketamine, 12 numbers of fluids such as correction fluid and diluters, 550gms of dendrite, 148.01ltrs of thinner and 203ml bottles of Corex syrup were seized.

RBP said that the increasing number of arrests is due to strict checking.

RBP official said, "Substance use is a slow poison to oneself, and it is literally going to kill the user. Please refrain from abusing such harmful substance."

"We are there to guide and correct every abuser by referring them to SUD centers. However, for traffickers, it is a serious crime, and also as per law they will be penalized. These people are spoiling many youths and adults just for fast and easy money. We have zero tolerance for them."

Feasibility of special school in Yonphula for students struggling with substance use

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

In response to the alarming rise in substance abuse cases, especially among the youth, Bhutan has taken significant steps to address this pressuring issue.

As of December 2023, a total of 3,472 individuals were arrested for substance abuse, with 1,815 falling under the age category of 24. While numbers are concerning, most of the individuals are referred for treatment assessment or prison-based treatment.

By March 2024, the Royal Bhutan Police (RBP) had already arrested 628 individuals in drug-related cases, indicating a continued need for intervention.

The National Drug Task Force (NDTF) has directed the Ministry of Education and Skills Development (MoESD) to expedite the establishment of a special school in Yonphula, Trashigang.

The government's allocation of approximately Nu 538 million in 2023 towards addressing drug-related cases among students highlights the severity of the situation.

During a recent press session, the Prime Minister highlighted the importance of raising awareness among students and proposed the introduction of mandatory drug tests in schools. This measure aims to address substance-related problems among youths promptly to prevent further drug related cases.

The establishment of a specialized school for students struggling with substance use marks a crucial point in Bhutan's battle against addiction. Moreover, rising drug cases and only 7 treatment centers in Bhutan are concerning thus, the establishment of a special school in Yonphula could also help to decongest the Chamgang jail.

His Majesty The King's Address during the 115th National Day also highlights the seriousness of the situation which called for a united effort to tackle substance abuse effectively.

NDTF advocates for a unified approach, focusing on mental health screening rather than immediate drug testing. This initiative aims to categorize students based on various factors, including depression, anxiety disorders, adverse childhood experiences, and substance abuse.

Despite challenges in finalizing details and implementing the specialized school, the government's commitment and the extensive approach adopted by NDTF indicates an encouraging step towards safeguarding society and ensuring a brighter future.

Led by the Prime Minister and supported by key governmental figures, NDTF's directive to MoESD to establish a special school also represents a bold response to the rising issues of substance abuse.

While the establishment of a specialized school for students struggling with substance use marks Bhutan's battle against addiction, it also raises ethical concerns regarding segregation and stigmatization.

Placing all students facing drug-related challenges in one institution may incidentally reinforce stereotypes and impede their integration into mainstream education and society. Therefore, creating a school dedicated to addressing substance abuse among students necessitates a careful approach to ensure an environment that is both supportive and inclusive.

Here a official said the school will keep the students permanently but it will be for a certain while as they recover and then they will be sent to other schools.

Third phase of Centenary Farmers' Market in progress

Dechen Wangmo / *Thimphu*

Most of the vendors were happy to move into a newly renovated floor of CFM complete with food stalls and an aesthetic space to sit and relax.

The ground floor of CFM, where imported vegetables and fruits are sold, is currently being renovated.

According to the Deputy Chief Urban Planner and Architect, Dorji Yangki, the third phase of the renovation work on CFM is on schedule for June 2024.

She said, "Before starting the project, we carefully looked at what was good and what needed fixing in the existing structure. Our goal is to keep the good parts while making others better, like adding wooden elements to soften the look of the concrete and making more space for everyone on the first floor."

She said the design ensures the shoppers and visitors can move around easily, and there is a separate space for workers and the public.

"Right now, we're excited about tearing down a wall to make a big open area with seats and stuff to make it nicer for everyone. We're also working with the electric company to get rid of poles and wires and put everything underground. Overall, we want to make the place much better, nicer, and easier to access for everyone," she added.

Further she said, "It's really important to listen to what people have to say, especially those who are directly involved like vendors, customers, and service providers. People seem happy with what we're doing, but keeping things clean is tough. We're dealing with litter and people not using public areas properly, but we're trying to fix it. We hope that by raising awareness and getting people to think more about it, things will get better over time."

The revitalization of CFM, now known as Kaja Throm, started with the first phase on the first floor on 26 June 2022. The north side on the first floor was completed on 17 December 2022.

The second phase, which is the central and south sides, was completed on 31 August 2023. It was officially opened to the public on 18 September 2023.

The third phase is the ground floor, and the site development is under renovation.

Govt ready to provide subsidies for tourism marketing but not willing to change SDF related policies

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

A slew of recommendations and reports have been submitted to the government on increasing tourist numbers from both the Ministry of Industry Commerce and Employment and other stakeholders.

A senior official, on the condition of anonymity said, the government will study all the recommendations carefully but is unlikely to arbitrarily change policies as too much of this has already happened and only where absolutely necessary they will change policies.

The main focus is in marketing without touching too many things.

The official said, all efforts would first be made to market Bhutan as an exclusive and attractive tourist destination and then they will look at other measures.

The senior official said, "Unless we market properly and thoroughly, tinkering with policies is not going to be the solution. We want to be very careful as it is confusing our tour operators, travel agents and tourists themselves."

On the plight of hotels in border towns the official said they have been asked to first make use of the 24-hours SDF free incentive but even with the 24 hours SDF free they are not able to compete.

The official said that if on first night they are fully booked and second night the tourist goes Jaigaon then they can understand but they are already enjoying one night without SDF and are still empty. The official asked how increasing the SDF free duration is going to add to it.

"Number one let us not tinker with SDF and policies and number two lets us focus on marketing," said the official.

Hoteliers in the border have been asked to give proposals to the government whereby they can go to India to market to tourists directly and the government will subsidize the marketing.

The official said the problem is the lack of marketing and not the SDF saying that Jaigaon is marketing and that is why tourists are staying there, even if it is for one night.

The official asked why a tourist coming to Bhutan is spending one night in Jaigaon and comes up to Thimphu when SDF is free in Phuentsholing for a night.

The official said they are spending the night in Jaigaon because it is the Jaigaon tour operators and hoteliers that are marketing to theses tourists and not Bhutanese.

"So, playing with SDF is not going to help and what is going to help is marketing which is the hard work and we have to put in the hard work," said the official.

When asked how numbers can be increased in the east the senior official said, "Again you market. Right now, you are starting from a very low base. You can't expect to have the same number of tourists as the other places but you can target to double, triple and quadruple.

Once you target then you implement your marketing plan and so if you don't market, other policy initiatives will have very limited impact."

The official said that in the east, the government has told the hoteliers and tour operators to invite tour operators who are based in Thimphu to the east and talk to them and encourage them to make tour programs.

If need be they will be subsidized.

"People from the east, including Dzongdas, should visit Thimphu and promote their areas and Dzongkhags with the tour operators here."

The government has also given instructions to the Department of Tourism to make special packages for the east.

They will also be encouraged to go to Guwahati and have special programs there and the government will support and monetary support too.

The senior official said if Bhutan is getting this many tourists with literally zero marketing then with a little marketing or targeted marketing how much can Bhutan get and how many tourists are going to come.

The senior official said the concern is not that we won't get enough but that we will hit our 300,000 target soon when the carrying capacity is limited.

The rock of Takti as a living monument of cultural and spiritual narratives

The large rock, located a few kilometers from the Chhukha bridge on the way to Gedu, is likely a familiar sight for regular commuters. Beyond its noticeable presence along the highway, this large stone holds cultural and historical significance. Its significance is deeply rooted in local beliefs and traditions, often tied to spiritual narratives or historical occurrences that have played a role in shaping the cultural heritage of the region. Serving as a landmark along the route, it stands as a tangible reminder of the area's rich history, prompting travelers to reflect on its meaning as they journey through. In the course of road expansion efforts, Dantak laborers attempted to blast this rock, making multiple endeavors to facilitate the progress of the road. Despite employing various methods, it was believed that their attempts to destroy the rock proved unsuccessful.

The significance of the rock lies in its preservation of the hoof prints left by Tertoen Drukdra Dorji's pony, Balaha, believed to manifestation of Chenrigzig. According to the narrative, the dense forest harbored a malicious demon that posed a threat to traders crossing the traditional trade route, making it a perilous location comparable to Trongsa Nyala, where historical travelers faced harm from the infamous Nyala Duem. Responding to traders' appeals during a journey to Pasakha, Tertoen subdued the demon in a formidable manifestation while riding his horse, Chep Ta, pressing its hooves onto the demon's abode. The enduring marks of hooves and Tertoen's seal signified the cessation of harm, accompanied by a commitment to refrain from causing distress to humans. Consequently, the place was named 'Tathil' རྟ་མཐིལ་ meaning '**forefoot of horse**,' where '*Ta*' denotes horse, and '*Thil*' terminology signifies '*forefoot.*' However, over time, the locale has acquired various names such as Takti, Taktikhoti, and Tatigang.

Expanding on the tales of place name origins, there's a fascinating story featuring Tsang Khenchen, a respected Tibetan Master. According to accounts from Tshang Khenchen's autobiography, he is said to have traveled through Cooch Bihar using a route similar to those previously described. In this story, another name, 'Tagkthil,' སྟ་གཐ་མཐིལ། emerges. However, the available information lacks in-depth details regarding the significance and origin of the associated name. As a result, it can be reasonably concluded that the place has been designated by multiple names.

The narrative unfolds with Khenchen's specific task of creating Dolma statues on stone slabs, set amidst a densely populated forest and imposing cliffs. This artistic venture blends with the natural surroundings, adding a unique dimension to the story and influencing the place name.

Consequently, the roots of the place name can be linked back to Tsang Khenchen's time, providing not just linguistic insights but also a captivating historical context. The interplay between artistic expression and the local geography plays a significant role in shaping the toponym. This layered narrative enhances our understanding of how the place name evolved, revealing the cultural and historical intricacies tied to its naming.

By Thukten Tenzin
Former History Teacher

RCSC unveils performance dashboard to enhance civil service evaluation

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

The Royal Civil Service Commission (RCSC) made news when it unveiled plans to introduce a comprehensive Performance Dashboard (PD) system that aims to provide a structured framework for evaluating individual civil servants' performance.

PD is designed to align closely with organizational objectives and key performance indicators, and aims to serve as a transparent roadmap outlining what each civil servant is expected to achieve within the fiscal year.

The innovative idea, introduced alongside the Managing for Excellence framework in 2017 and refined over time, aims to enhance objectivity and reduce subjectivity in performance assessment.

According to an official from RCSC, the Performance Dashboard will facilitate regular updates on individual performance, allowing supervisors to provide directives and adjustments as necessary. This dynamic tool not only aids in monitoring progress, but also creates an engagement between supervisors and supervisees, ultimately leading to improved organizational outcomes.

The official also emphasized the crucial role of PD in helping supervisors track organizational result areas and make necessary adjustments throughout the year.

By incorporating target-setting, continuous monitoring, and year-end evaluation, the PD forms the basis for performance moderation, taking into account the competencies of civil servants at different position levels.

To further enhance the effectiveness of PD, the RCSC has announced plans to conduct a review of performance management within the health and education sectors.

A recent review meeting focusing on performance management for health professionals saw collaboration between the National Medical Services, RCSC, and health experts from Singapore. The commission has decided to adopt PD changes and improve current PDs for all heads of department in the health sector, while also rolling out new features for school leaders and staff, including standard performance dashboards and moderation mechanics.

RCSC's introduction of PD system signifies a significant step towards enhancing civil service evaluation. With its transparent framework, personalized work plans, and ongoing refinement, PD promises to improve objectivity and accountability, revolutionizing performance assessment processes across diverse sectors.

Women do not feel safe after a spate of crimes

Dechen Wangmo & Tshering Dema / *Thimphu*

The concerns over women's safety has become a growing topic in recent times, prompting widespread discussions and calls for action. In both urban and rural settings, women are fearful with various associated risks and challenges when navigating public spaces, particularly at night.

Thinley, who is a mother of two daughters, shared that with the recent crimes against women, where one was murdered and another raped in her own residence, she feels very insecure having her daughters go out. In fact, she has totally stopped letting them hang out with their friends too.

She said, "Until now, I have always thought that women are safe in our country compared to other countries. Normally, I tell my daughters that they can go out and that it is safe. I never gave a second thought. But then, when such news come, it is shocking to know that we are not safe anymore. As soon as I heard this news, I told my two daughters that it is not safe in Thimphu."

"We cannot take anything for granted now, and we should be more vigilant and know at the back of our mind that now with many social problems, we never know of other people's mental status. Parents monitoring also plays a crucial role here," she added.

Further she said, "Not only about security concerns while going out, but also in recent news a rape of a 19-year-old girl in her sleep and in her residence, this has left me totally in shock."

Similarly, a high school graduate, Phuntsho Wangmo, said she has experienced fear and discomfort when walking alone at night. One precaution she has adopted is keeping her phone readily accessible for emergencies. However, as the situation persists, she has chosen to remain indoors rather than risk potential harm.

She said, "To address these issues, widespread education is imperative, emphasizing the importance of understanding and respecting women's safety. It is crucial to remove the belief that women are at fault for being out at night. Rather we need to shift the focus towards ensuring their safety regardless of the time or location."

She addressed that particular areas of vulnerability for women include clubs and secluded locations outside urban centers. While she is not personally familiar with club environments, she shares that reports highlight heightened risks for women in such settings.

She further said, "Implementing measures like increased surveillance and robust security can help mitigate these risks, alongside comprehensive educational initiatives promoting women safety at all societal levels."

Yeshi Choden, who is pursuing master degree, shared that first of all they should stop victim blaming women, and start supporting victims when they face abuse.

She said, "Other questionable things might include being open to receiving complaints, proper street lights in narrow alleys, increasing watch outs in places with high crime rate, closing of clubs after midnight, more patrols during night time, and educating young girls and boys at school about safety. Also, strict laws against sexual assault and abuse, teaching women basic self-defense skills, making self-defense items available for women."

Pema Wangmo, another high school graduate shared that, "I am fortunate enough to have been born in a country where women rights are acknowledged, so I feel it is quite safe to walk alone, even at night. However, I still avoid places that are crowded by men, bars, and dark alleys while walking alone at night as an extra precaution."

Many women shared that everyone needs to put an effort in building a conducive environment, where women can be assured that they are safe. Parenting, schools and community as a whole need to work together.

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cont. from pg 01

Assessment for Saturday off or not finds curriculum too heavy and teachers doing too many things

would do an online and on the ground assessment and diagnosis of the schools and curriculum.

The MoESD had said the team will submit a complete report to the cabinet and based on the report a decision will be taken on Saturday off.

It has been learnt that Cambridge International has finished its survey almost a month ahead of its original May deadline and is in the process of presenting it to the MoESD.

The team not only did online assessment but it also went on the field and met with teachers, principals and schools across Dzongkhags.

One of the findings of the survey is that the curriculum in Bhutan is too heavy and in some cases, there was repetition too.

Another finding was that teachers are doing too many things by being involved in multiple programs like sports, cultural activity etc.

The survey has also found that quality of Bhutanese education is not good compared to the international standard. It has found some of the curriculum is close to the international level and some are not.

There is a need to revise the curriculum.

The MoESD is expected to get a complete presentation of the report and then work on it and then present it to the cabinet with the next two weeks.

The cabinet will deliberate on the report by Cambridge International and then a final decision will have to be taken on weather Saturday off is to be given or not.

While it is not known what the cabinet will decide, the Cambridge Report indicating that students and teachers are overburdened already strengthens the argument for Saturday off.

However, it will also not be so simple as if the Saturday off is to be given then the curriculum will have to be thinned out and how that can be managed needs to be seen.

In fact, one of the main arguments by those against having Saturday off is the fear of not finishing the curriculum.

From the report, it is clear that the focus in the Bhutanese education needs to be more on quality than just quantity.

There is tremendous pressure on the government to fulfil its pledge and the Education Minister Yeezang D. Thapa in the past said the MoESD wants to give it but a decision is not yet taken.

A source said, "We made a lot of progress and you can expect an announcement next week. The survey is almost done and we got a lot of experts to look into it and we have looked into it and we consulted many people. Now we feel confident to take a decision."

cont. from pg 01

MoESD and RCSC agree to changes in IWP for teachers

Service Commission have finally been able to agree to some changes on the matter.

The first thing is that ECCDS, Extended Classrooms (ECRs) and certain schools that have less than 10 teachers will not be included in the moderation exercise for the bell curve.

There are 166 such ECCDs, ECRs and schools with less than 10 teachers.

Another change is that for schools with a 20% percent or more shortage of teachers then they will also not come under moderation exercise and bell curve as long as they meet the minimal performance requirements.

Here the MoESD will have to convince the RCSC why these schools should not be moderated.

Earlier moderation exercise was done at the Dzongkhag level and moderation for primary and high schools were done together, but now it will be done at the national level and the moderation for primary schools and high schools will be done separately.

An important change which is also part of the larger change in the civil service is that the Key Performance Indicators to measure performance will not only be at the school level but also at the principal and teachers individual level.

This means using the Performance Dashboard tool of the RCSC the individual performance of teachers can be tracked.

An official in the MoESD said the ministry discussed the matter with teachers and they are happy with the changes.

The Prime Minister Dasho Tshering Tobgay said, "Teachers have no problem with IWP. They do their lesson planning anyway. They are very hardworking and very systematic and they have been trained and retrained. IWP is something they are doing anyway. The problem they have is with the moderation exercise where a certain number of people under the Bell Curve are put in in Needs Improvement (now renamed Partly Meeting Expectations)."

The PM said he joins all the teachers in questioning this logic for the simple reason that it is not possible statistically to apply a bell curve to a very small group.

Bhutanverse - A gateway to Bhutan's cultural exploration

Sonam Tshomo Tshering / *Thimphu*

On 25 July 2023, Bhutanverse, a Metaverse-based virtual environment, was announced to be launched by the Druk Holding and Investments (DHI) during the FAB23 Bhutan International Conference in Thimphu.

Bhutanverse integrates distinctive Bhutanese motifs, art, and architecture, and provides users worldwide with a thorough experience of Bhutan's culture, history, and philosophy. In collaboration with Smobler and the Sandbox, DHI aimed to develop a digital experience, in order to enable consumers worldwide to delve into Bhutan's rich culture, history, and philosophy from any location.

The Bhutanverse team was very active through the InnoTech and DHI social media channels, and they generally received positive reactions from the Bhutanese community upon the announcement of the launch of Bhutanverse.

In honor of His Majesty The King's 44th Birth Anniversary, DHI formally launched Bhutanverse on the open Metaverse platform of the Sandbox on 21 February 2024.

The first version showcases non-fungible tokens (NFT) made by regional artists in Bhutan, and includes an Art Gallery that was co-created with TheUpsideSpace. Engaging adventures based on engrossing tales from Bhutan's history and mythology are available in the creative area created by Bhutanese developers.

The Sandbox provides access to Bhutanverse, a platform where creators will determine its accessibility to all segments of Bhutanese Society. For the time being, anyone with a computer and an internet connection can use the Sandbox platform to log in and play the game for free. The Bhutanverse team anticipate that tablets and smartphones will be able to access the platform by the end of 2024. Since this is a trial initiative, they concentrated on developing capacity and skills. In the future, they will emphasize on accessibility and inclusivity for the Bhutanese people as they work to grow the Metaverse community in Bhutan.

Smobler trained a team from DHI and a variety of local people to develop the experience and produce the assets. "Learning how to utilize GameMaker and VoxEdit was the most difficult part of the process. There weren't any real issues after the boot camp, once the crew was comfortable using the program", the team from DHI expressed.

As of now, Bhutanverse remains a proof of concept project with the digital art/NFT gallery and two localized games. The team hopes that through experiencing the Bhutanverse, different age groups of the Bhutanese public become interested in learning more about building on the metaverse. As part of the gallery, there is space for DHI to collaborate with local artists (of all ages) to transform their art into voxel art for display or for individuals to try their hand at creating different assets inspired by Bhutanese culture.

DHI is actively exploring additional use cases, most of which will pertain to preserving and digitizing Bhutanese culture and tradition. As part of exploring the Metaverse, DHI bought a 3 x 3 plot of LAND on The Sandbox. Through this project, they were able to utilize a 2 x 2, and a 1 x 1 plot. They hope to engage with more enthusiasts through training, workshops, and ideathons to develop the remaining plots of LAND.

There is potential to collaborate in the near future with various platform developers and tech specialists. Requirements for these partnerships include use cases, resources, and strategic alignment with overarching objectives.

Sudoku

6		3		1	
	4		1		5
3		2		4	
	1		3		6
1		5		6	
	3		6		2

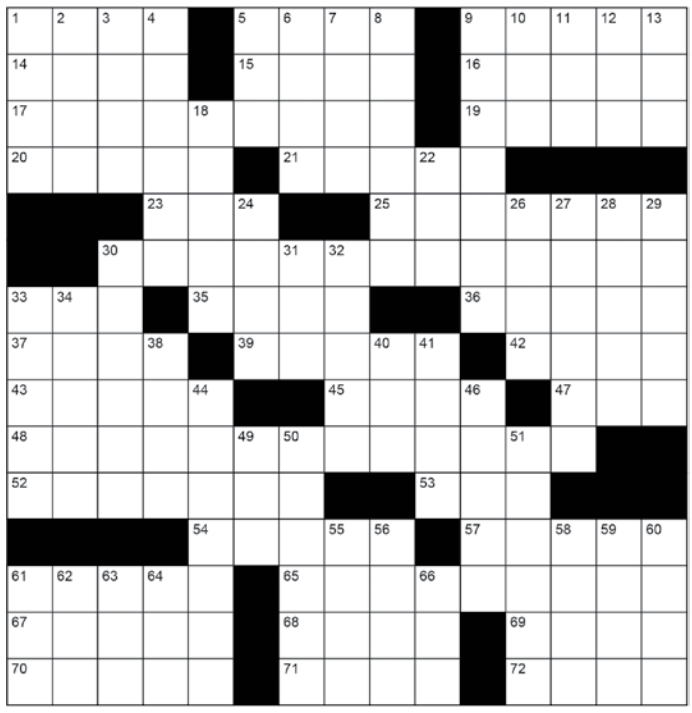
Difficult rating: ***

answer next issue

Last issue Answers

3	1	6	4	5	2
4	5	2	3	6	1
1	4	3	6	2	5
6	2	5	1	4	3
5	6	1	2	3	4
2	3	4	5	1	6

Crossword puzzles



Across

1. ____ means (not at all)
5. Some SUVs
9. Lines of the treble clef
14. Shark's offer
15. It may be common or proper
16. Thread holder
17. Admitted
19. Hamburger round
20. Mrs. Cliff Huxtable
21. ___ dabba do
23. ___-wop
25. Head scarf
30. Rehab centers
33. Itsy-bitsy
35. "Casablanca" role, Ilsa ____
36. Slow down
37. Ship's framework
39. Under oath
42. Zap with a stunning weapon
43. "How may ___ service?"
45. Felt remorseful over
47. Brig. ___
48. James Joyce classic
52. Ate like a horse
53. Only even prime number
54. Cookie morsel
57. Dickens' Drood
61. Take ___ (lose a bundle)
65. Land famed for its cuisine
67. Indian corn
68. Jeff Bridges film
69. Where you can be all you can be
70. "Hannah Montana" star Miley
71. Place for dirty dishes
72. Metal janglers on a ring

Down

1. Soviet ___
2. Distressed scream
3. Grandma, to some
4. Iroquoian people
5. Safari sight
6. 1997 cyberpet
7. ____ rug (boogie)
8. Socially exclusive
9. "Lengua" on a peseta
10. College transcript no.
11. Cyborg, for short
12. ___-com bubble
13. Pesky insect
18. Comical
22. Scrooge outburst
24. Joan Osborne hit, "One ___"
26. Twosome
27. "All the world's ___"
28. North Carolina river
29. Trembling tree
30. Montana capital
31. Opposite of ESE
32. Accessorize, maybe
33. Waft
34. Jazzman Blake
38. Chaney and Fuller
40. Ukr. neighbor
41. Eft
44. Gets
46. 1920's vice president Charles
49. Neighbor of Belg.
50. Grownups
51. Big bear
55. Memento ____
56. ___ Ma Thuot (Vietnamese prov. capital)
58. House lead-in
59. The Beatles' "____ Life"
60. Negatives
61. FX competitor
62. Reddish-brown horse
63. Hang out to dry
64. Shih ___ (dog)
66. Squid squirt

WEATHER

SATURDAY

Thimphu
Max: 16°C
Min: 04 °C

Trashigang
Max: 25 °C
Min: 17 °C

Trongsa
Max: 18 °C
Min: 09 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 35 °C
Min: 20 °C

SUNDAY

Thimphu
Max: 17 °C
Min: 04 °C

Trashigang
Max: 24 °C
Min: 18 °C

Trongsa
Max: 20 °C
Min: 11 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 38 °C
Min: 20 °C

Source: https://www.accuweather.com/en/bt/bhutan-weather

ZAKAR

SATURDAY

Good day *to appease local deities, start education, appoint to new post, enter new house, hold good discussion, shift house, approach higher authority, hand and take over office and sow seeds.*

Bad day *to start new business, astrological predictions and divinations for both dead and living.*

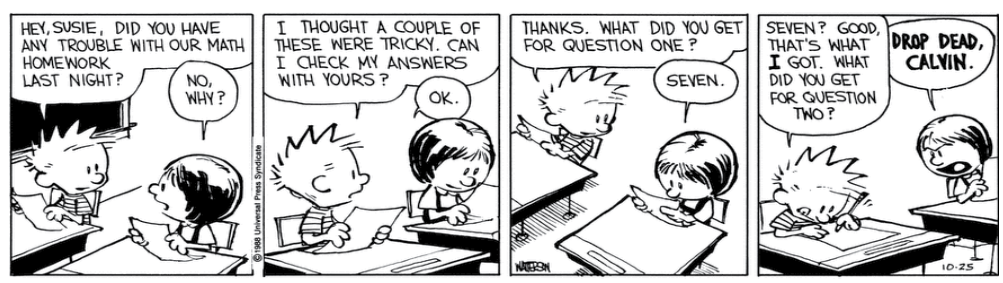
SUNDAY

Good day t*o make annual and scheduled calender offerings only.*

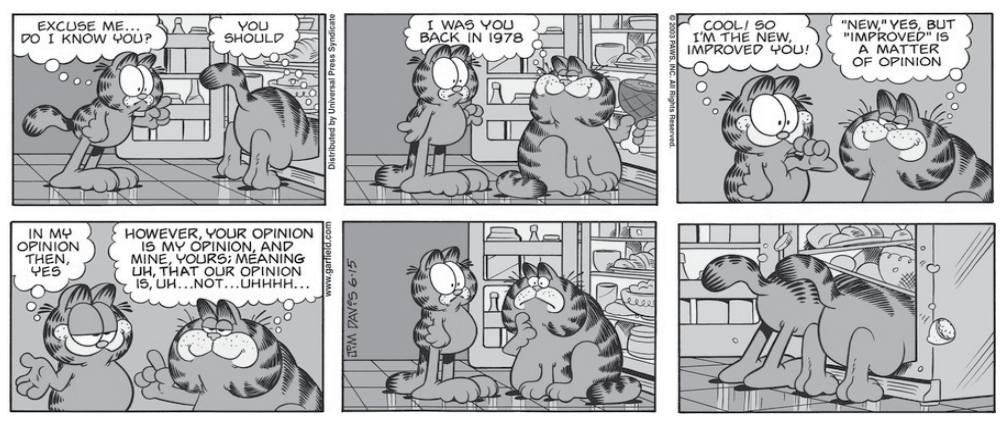
Bad day *to appease local deities, appoint to new post, shift house, enter new house, start new business, long journey and hold good discussions.*

Source: Dratshang Lhentshog

calvin & hobbes



garfield



STCBL to open 5 fuel retail outlets to help with fuel shortages

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

STCBL is set to open additional Fuel Retail Outlets (FROs), with 3 at Nobding, Chumme and Daga Throm within a month. 2 FROs are to be commissioned by the end of this year in Gakiling, Haa and Nganglam, Pema Gatshel.

Officials from STCBL shared there were many requests for a FRO from many dungkhags across Bhutan, and STCBL is looking into the matter on case-by-case basis.

They shared that since investment cost is relatively high and rate of return is slow, STCBL had to analyze the business viability of that particular areas prior to commitment.

An official said, "We do the business analysis and give the commitment. We have recently signed an agreement with Dagana dzongkhag for leasing land at Lhamoizingkha and drawings are also approved. Likely, we will start construction by early year as we have not budgeted this year as we are unsure for land on lease."

As for other dzongkhags, STCBL shared that there are already other fuel dealers operated by BOD or Damchen petroleum distributors, and there is a need to look into the financial viability and costs.

"I don't have idea about other POL dealers but we follow proper SOP and quality assurance for amount paid. However, profit margin is Nu 1 per liter for POL dealer which is very less and DOT has deducted financial cost, Product loss, and Transit Insurance from the pricing structure".

As of 28 February 2024, STCBL has commissioned 7 FROs.

As for any shortage or dry out at the fuel station, Department of trade (DOT) can penalize the POL dealers as per their guidelines. DOT has equally monitored the fuel stock and shortages.

As per DOT instruction in 2018, all POL dealers must import Euro VI/BS VI fuel.

ROYAL GOVERNMENT OF BHUTAN
ANTI-CORRUPTION COMMISSION
'NATION'S CONSCIENCE'
"LEAD BY EXAMPLE"
"If you care, you will dare"

PROHIBITION ORDER

In exercise of power conferred under § 24 (1) (g) of the Anti-Corruption Act of Bhutan (ACAB) 2011, the Anti-Corruption Commission (the Commission) hereby prohibits the following business entities from entering into any new contractual relationship with public agencies upon finding *prima facie* case of corruption:

Sl. No.	Name of business entity	License No.	Type of activity
1	GY Ventures, Thimphu	R1010260	General, Electronic Shop Retail of TV/Radio, Refrigerator, and other electric/ Electronic Appliances, Retail of Computers and Software
2	LINK UNIFY, Thimphu	R1006223	Production and Manufacturing, Service or Trade
3	SPD Automobile, Thimphu	R1044440	Automobile Workshop
4	Zealous Systems Private Ltd., Thimphu	R1003124	Trade
5	SPD Spare Parts	R1012399	Retail of Auto parts and Accessories

This prohibition order shall not affect any on-going contractual obligation effected prior to the issuance of this order.

This prohibition order shall remain in effect pending the outcome of the case unless otherwise revoked or rescinded by the Commission. Non-compliance to the Commission's lawful demand constitutes an offence under § 113 (1) (c) of the ACAB 2011.

Issued under the seal and signature of the Commission on **17th Day** of **April** of the **Year 2024**.

Chairperson

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)
BRO PROJECT DANTAK (BHUTAN)
TENDER NO. HQ 19 BRTF/NIT/07 OF 2024-25

Commander, 19 BRTF, invites tender from the eligible contractors for the following works:-

Particulars of Work	Cost/ Time of work	Details of Tender Documents
SUPPLY AND STACKING OF STONE METAL 40MM STONE CHIPS 20 MM,STONE CHIPS 12.5 MM AND SAND FOR PMT WORKS BETWEEN KM 0.000 TO KM 61.546, DUMPLING LOCATION AT KM 10.000 UNDER PART-'A' AND KM 51.00 UNDER PART –'B' ON KHOTAKPA-TSHOBALEY ROAD (AS PER MORT&H PECIFICATIONS) UNDER 64 RCC/19 BRTF PROJECT DANTAK INSIDE BHUTAN (NIT No. 19 BRTF-07/2024-25) **Tender ID No : 2024_BRO_753846_1**	(a) Cost of Tender : **Nil** (b) Cost of Work : **Rs 141.86 lakh** (c) Earnest Money : **Rs.2,16,860.00 only** (d) Period of Completion : **180 days**	(a) Availability of tender on Central Public Procurement Portal on or after : **22 Apr 2024** (b) Last date of submission of tender documents : **13 May 2024 (1200 hrs BST)** (c) 'T' – Bid opening date : **13 May 2024 (1500 Hrs BST)**

Note:- Full notice of tender any change in above details, tender document (including eligibility criteria) and other details may be obtained from **http://eprocure.gov.in/epublish/app** for any queries, please contact on telephone **009755 252228** and Fax **009755 252229**

Zhung Dratshang offers Ku-Sung-Thukten Mendrel to HH Kyabgon Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche

His Holiness Kyabgon Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche was received by His Eminence Dorji Lopen and other Lopens of the Zhung Dratshang at Puna Dewa Chhenpoi Phodrang

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

The Zhung Dratshang or the Central Monastic Body announced on its official facebook page that on the 8th day of the 3rd lunar month, His Holiness Kyabgon Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche was received by His Eminence Dorji Lopen and other Lopens of the Zhung Dratshang at Puna Dewa Chhenpoi Phodrang.

The Zhung Dratshang also offered Ku-Sung-Thukten Mendrel to His Holiness the Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche.

His Eminence Dzongsar Jamyang Khyentse Rinpoche accompanied His Holiness.

The post said the Zhung Dratshang (Pel Drukpa Kagyu tradition) and the Sakya Lineage share cordial relations since the 17th Century, with the 24th Sakya Trichen Jamyang Sonam Wangpo offering a long life prayer for Kyabgoen Ngawang Namgyel.

Kyabgon Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche has been on a visit since 9 April where he was received at the airport by Dzongsar Jamyang Khyentse Rinpoche who considers him his root guru.

Sakya Gongma Trichen Rinpoche on 10 April visited the Shechen Thegchok Chokyi Gatsel in Paro Satsam Chorten in Bhutan. Rinpoche blessed the Phurba Lhakang and Kudung Chorten and gave blessing to the devotees.

Rinpoche also visited the Kyichu Lhakhang in Paro.

In Thimphu Rinpoche conferred Kago to devotees gathered at the Memorial Choten.

He also visited the Anim Dratshang in Zilukha where he gave blessings and he said in English that this is his first visit to Bhutan and he the whole atmosphere is differet and he felt he is in the pure realm. He said everywhere there is temples and stupas.

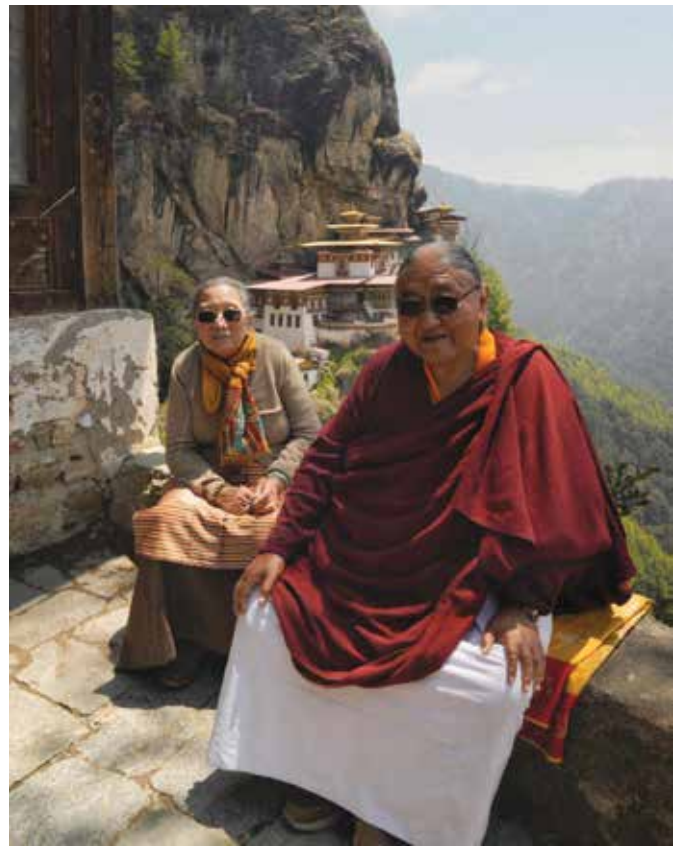
Rinpoche said he has been to many countries but he has never seen an atmosphere like this and so he is very happy.

Sakya Rinpoche said he visited many temples which are very ancient and when he entere there he can feel there is a great blessing and spiritual power.

Sakya Rinpoche said he had an audience with His Majesty The King, Her Majesty The Gyaltsuen and other Royal Family members. He said Their Majesties are so great persons but are so humble and were very kind to them. He said this is a real Dharma King.

He said the good life, development and modern amenities enjoyed by Bhutanese are due to His Majesty The Fourth King and His Majesty The King.

"So therefore, everybody should remember their kindness and pray for them to live long and fulfill their noble aspirations. I will also pray that they will have a very long life and to fulfil their great wishes," said Sakya Rinpoche.



Rinpoche then left for Bumthang and on the way halted at Trongsa. Sakya Rinpoche visited Chendebji Choeten for lunch hosted by the communities and Dzongkhag office of Trongsa.

Upon arrival in Bumthang, the Dratshang of Tharpaling received him in Gaytsa. He then visited Lhodrak Karchu Dratshang to bestow oral transmissions of Mañjuśrīnāmasamgīti and the Vajrakilaya protection-blessing.

In the afternoon he visited the Kurjey Lhakhang to conduct Tshokhor at the Guru Lhakhang.

Rinpoche visited Jambey Lhakhang and the seats of Pema Lingpa Tamshing Lhakhang and Kenchosum Lhakhang. Kyabgon Rinpoche bestowed the Tsewang Logyama (Chimed Pater) long life empowerment of Thangtong Gyalpo to over 20,000 devotees from all across Bhutan.

After the special visited to Punakha Dzong Sakya Rinpoche visited the Taktsang Monastery.

Why NCHM could not predict the hailstorm in Tsirang

Monica Rai/ *Thimphu*

The recent hailstorm wreaked havoc on the agricultural sector in Tsirang, adding to a series of extreme weather events that have affected Bhutan this year. The hailstorm struck on 10 April, causing significant damage to crops and leaving locals grappling with the aftermath.

In February, the country was under the influence of a western disturbance and moisture from the Arabian Sea, resulting in mostly cloudy weather with light rainfall/snowfall across Northern, Western, Central, and Eastern parts of Bhutan. Strong western disturbances in early February also brought gusty winds to several regions, including Gasa, Thimphu, Haa, Paro, and Wangdue.

Explaining the cause of the hailstorm in Damphu, meteorologists highlighted the atmospheric instability during the spring season in Bhutan. The region experiences a mix of cold northerly winds and warm southerly winds, leading to atmospheric instability conducive to hailstorms and thunderstorms.

The National Center for Hydrology and Meteorology (NCHM) official said, "The presence of a cyclonic circulation southwest of Bhutan resulted in moisture feeding into the southern regions. When this moisture-laden wind from the southwest interacted with the south-facing slopes of places like Damphu, it created an upward rising action, forming thick and tall clouds."

"These conditions provided the perfect environment for the formation of hailstorms. Additionally, windy conditions contributed to an increased presence of dust particulates in the air, further aiding hailstone formation," the official added.

Despite advancements in meteorological forecasting, predicting localized phenomena like hailstorms remains a challenge. An official from NCHM stated that while their forecast models have a resolution of 3 km, they failed to predict the Damphu hailstorm. The official attributed this to the complexity of simulating relatively small-scale weather processes in the context of country's unique topography.

However, NCHM remains committed to improving their models to better forecast such events in the future.

In the wake of the hailstorm, residents of Damphu, Tsirang are seeking assistance from the government. The hailstorm has caused extensive damage to crops, raising concerns about food security and livelihoods in the region.

cont. from pg 01

3 Drug Convicts in Chamgang share how they got into drugs, the drug culture in Bhutan, the drug trade and the big fishes

divorce the third time.

Sonam said, "My divorced mother was a house wife and she had to look after me and my two younger sisters. It was very tough for us and my mother went through so much hardship to provide for us and raise us."

"Due to all this childhood trauma I felt very shameful, lost my confidence and had a lot of anxiety and I was not like a normal student who could make normal friends," said Sonam.

Sonam said that as he rose up the classes his anxiety and lack of confidence in himself only grew especially since he had to start making presentations in class and in college. He started taking drugs to build up his confidence and also escape his reality.

He continued taking drugs in NIE Paro but he did well enough academically to pass his courses and even make it through the RCSC exams to get a job as a teacher.

After becoming a teacher Sonam tried to control his drug habit and brought down his pill consumption drastically from a high of 24 to 32 SP+ pills a day to a low of 3 to 2 pills a day.

Sonam could not quit his habit completely though he was on the verge of it and so he thought a change of location to Australia would help him to quit completely and also earn more money to help his two younger sisters and his mother.

Sonam said he had addict friends like himself who went to Australia and became clean.

He applied for further studies in Australia and got through and even got his visa and he was supposed to fly on 28th August 2023.

On the 6 th of August 2023 Sonam went to Jaigaon to replenish his SP+ plus supplies and so he bought around 100 SP+ tablets.

"I was not caught at the main Phuentsholing gate nor at the Amochu check post ahead but ultimately there was a small check post at Dorokha where I was caught," said Sonam.

Sonam said he was prosecuted and got five years since he had more than 21 tablets even though it was for personal consumption and not sale.

Sonam said he lost everything as he could not go to Australia, and even lost his teaching job which was helping support his sisters and his mother. He will come out only in 2028.

A College Student

Tshetim (name changed) is 32 years old and from Thimphu Thromde.

Tshetim said he is from a well-off family with land in Thimphu. He is the youngest of his siblings as his father and mother had him late.

Things changed for Tshetim when his 92-year-old father died, after which there was no father who ensured he came home on time and kept an eye on him.

Tshetim said his siblings were already married and they lived on their own. The loss of his father pushed him into depression, and he then started going around with the wrong group of friends. He was pampered and he could do what he wanted with no one to supervise or control him.

He said he moved around with friends who were in the 'drug life' but he, himself, did not touch drugs at the point.

Things changed for Tshetim when he started attending college in Dehra Dhun, and again got into the wrong company, going for parties and enjoying life on the fast lane. This is where Tshetim picked up a drug habit which started with weed and then went on to N 10 and SP+.

In fact, once he was high on N 10 and went on a bike ride with a friend from Kashmir, India but they met an accident with the car of a local Member of the Legislative Assembly (MLA). His friend died and he broke both his legs.

He finished his college but did not do well in one subject for which he had a back paper.

Tshetim came back to Bhutan and like many of the youths at the time he decided to go to Australia. Everything was in place for him but the consultancy told him he needed to get a complete graduation degree for which he needed to go back to India and do the back paper.

So, in 2018, he did the back paper in India and was coming back in via Phuentsholing when the police caught him with 10 boxes of SP+ which is around 1,400 tablets in total.

Tshetim was high on drugs in the Indian taxi he had booked and he said he did not even know what was happening.

Tshetim said the drugs were for personal consumption and not selling as he was heavily using SP+ by then going through 48 to 56 tablets a day.

He got bail in his case and he came to Thimphu.

However, while in Thimphu he was again caught with drugs when police caught a drug user friend of his and set a trap where the drug user asked him to get some drugs for him which he did from a supplier and he was caught again.

Given this was the second time he was caught in an ongoing trail the judge did not give the usual 5 years but increased the sentence to 7 years and 6 months.

He entered prison in 2018 and will get out only in 2026.

A Tour Guide

Jigme (name changed) aged 37 from Lhuentse was caught in 2016 with drugs that he was bringing from Siliguri for his consumption along with a friend.

He was not caught at the gate but the police who had been tipped off about him raided his hotel room and caught him and his friend.

Though small in quantity, given the nature of the drug they were carrying, Jigme got a jail sentence of 15 years which is from 2016 to 2032.

Jigme went in jail at the age of 30 and he will come out a 45-year-old man.

Jigme also came from a well-off family, however, things started falling apart for him when his father and mother divorced when he was 14 years old.

He said he stayed with his father and his mother moved on with a step-father.

He said his father would work late until 8 pm every day, and he was free to go where he wanted and do what he liked, and so he fell into bad company.

What also did not help was that a combination of guilt and pity led to Jigme getting large amounts of money from his father, mother and even his uncles and aunties.

So, when he turned 16 and was in class 8 he started by sniffing dendrite and then progressing up the drug ladder to weed, SP+, Relapin, etc.

Jigme had easy access to drugs in college in Bangalore from pharmacy shops there who sold him SP+ at INR 2 per tablet. He worked there for three years in a call center after graduation and then came back to help is grandfather run a hotel in Paro. Around this time, he became a tour guide.

He said his dealer in Thimphu who dealt in the specific drugs he used had been caught, and so he went to Siliguri to get it himself when he got caught on the way back.

Jigme with tears in his eyes and his voice cracking said, "I lost 12 of my friends to drug overdose. Two were deliberate suicide overdoses with my one friend not liking that his father remarried after his mother's death and another friend having marital problems with his wife."

Jigme said that those taking drugs should never mix it with alcohol as the combination in high doses can kill.

He said his friends were all from well off families, but either their parents were separated or they were given too much money and time with no proper parental guidance and supervision.

The Family Unit and early intervention

All three of the above said they did not want to blame their family members or situation, but ultimately what a child goes through at a young and vulnerable age, including trauma, plays a huge role in whether they pick up drug habits or not.

They also said the other important role of the family is not giving unlimited freedom and money to kids and to keep an eye out for them

Sonam said that he regrets now not seeking early help for his addiction due to which he has lost so much, but he was afraid of the stigma around drug addiction, the fear of losing his teaching job, how his colleagues would view him. He said the system views alcoholics sympathetically and there is help for them, but not so in the case of drug addiction.

Also given that all three of them got into drugs while in school or college early intervention and support at this stage is important too.

Drug availability and the drug trade

The vast majority of drugs that come into Bhutan are from across the border, and most of them come via Jaigaon through multiple dealers.

Both Sonam and Tshetim said that the moment they entered Jaigaon, strangers would walk up to them and ask them if they wanted drugs.

"Just by looking at the faces, they seem to know who are drug addicts and approach them," said Tshetim.

Sonam said that one of the main places where he used to get drugs in Jaigaon is behind the JB Supermarket.

They said drugs cannot be got easily from pharmacies, but there are several drug suppliers doing both retail and wholesale business.

Retailers sell a box of SP+ for Nu 2,000 while wholesalers give it for Nu 1,500 to Nu 1,000 per box.

The three of them said that while drugs user start with a small number of tablets, but as resistance builds up then a large number of tablets are required to get the same effect. At that stage when they try to quit, they get both physical and mental symptoms and an intense longing for the drug.

cont. on pg 11

cont. from pg 10

3 Drug Convicts in Chamgang share how they got into drugs, the drug culture in Bhutan, the drug trade and the big fishes

The drugs are brought up mainly by transporters transporting vegetables, groceries, supplies, etc., hoping to make extra income and also the unemployed or the desperate persons who have debts to pay off, like gambling debts.

Sonam said some of those include people without CID cards who could not get work opportunities at other places.

They said drugs were also being brought in via ambulances and via monks and in vehicles in the past which were not checked due to exceptions (they are all being checked now).

All three of them said the drugs are ordered by the 'Big Fishes' in Thimphu who put in the money and use transporters and drug peddlers in between, and so they are rarely caught as even a money trail to them is difficult to prove.

These big fishes use peddlers in Thimphu, Paro and other places so there is no risk for them as the RBP can only arrest them if they have evidence.

Sonam said drug users in Phuentsholing, to avoid getting caught with drugs on them, come to Jaigaon to the suppliers consume the drugs and head back.

He said while waiting at the house of the drug supplier in Jaigaon, during lunch break, he saw around 20 to 30 Bhutanese from Phuentsholing coming in to consume drugs within 10 minutes and then leaving.

In Thimphu, the drug is not available in shops, like tobacco once was when it was illegal, but there are specific dealers and peddlers.

Jigme said before there would be a group of youths to contact in Mothithang, another in Changangkha, Sabzi Bazar, etc.

They talked about one instance that they heard about, when a drug supplier from Jaigaon who carried the drugs on him, hiked away from the check posts through the forest carrying the drugs.

Jaigaon not only supplies drugs to Bhutan, but to youths from Sikkim and other places as well.

They said there is a suspicion that the same drug sellers may also be tipping of the RBP as there is a reward for drug informers, which means double profit.

An Appeal

All three of them said that the current legal provisions are too stringent, as anything above 21 SP+ tablets lead to a minimum 5-year term even though they all had brought in drugs for personal consumption.

Sonam said people like them should be given a second chance. He said they are ready to stay even for two years in rehab treatment, but away from Chamgang with the second year going in encouraging and helping new addicts.

Sonam said given the rate of drug consumption many more productive people could go behind bars.

Jigme said with the number of drug arrests there will be no space in prisons. He said earlier one needed to finish 75% of one's sentence to serve in open air prison, but it got reduced to 50% and is now 25% due to too many prisoners.

He said there are around 1,950 people in open air prisons working on various public projects and around half of them would be related to drug cases. He said people can access drugs in these open-air prisons, as they are allowed to go out shopping once a week.

Tshetim said that other countries have sentencing based on the amount of drugs caught, but here, somebody who brings more than 21 tablets and who brings in 7,000 tablets are both treated the same legally.

Jigme also said that prison time is the last thing an addict should through as the confinement only makes their condition worse.

He said in the past, there are those who got released and went back to drug use and peddling. He said this is because prison time, firstly leads to stigma, and then there are NOC issues for 3 to 5 years where they cannot make a livelihood or reintegrate back into society. He said more needs to be done on this front.

There is also the danger of drug users meeting hardened convicts inside and getting hardened in the process.

He and the others all welcomed the Substance Use Disorder (SUD) treatment program being implemented by the PEMA Secretariat in Chamgang, where around 420 are undergoing it. They said this is of great help.

Sonam pointed out there are many cases where young fathers have been arrested, but they have wives and young toddlers with no one to take care of them.

Jigme said more drug seizures will only push up drug prices, and this will tempt more to get into it as there will be more money to be made.

All three of them, based on their experiences, appealed to the youth to not take drugs as it would destroy their lives.

Jigme said, "Do not get into drugs as it is a one-time time enjoyment, but when you get caught your life feels like it finished."

He also said that even other crimes like murder, rape, burglary happens under the influence of drugs and alcohol.

Sonam said from being the main hope of the family, he cannot even take care of his sisters and his mother now.

Tshetim said that if youth cannot give up drugs to not have it in front of younger friends as it will give them wrong example and add glamour and acceptability to it, which is wrong.

All three of them also said the police information network on drug information is very sophisticated and youths abusing and transporting drugs have a high chance of getting caught.

cont. from pg 01

PM explains what the Nu 15 bn ESP will be used for

give subsidized, targeted and also some collateral free loans but through banks.

The PM said, "The expert group that we put together has completed their work on how best to use the ESP to stimulate our economy. We will need to discuss it in the cabinet. I am yet to receive the report."

He said people can expect a range of interventions to stimulate the economy including changes on policies that affect doing business and Foreign Direct Investment which is one part of it.

Lyonchhen said the country has been facing liquidity issues compounded by foreign currency or reserve concerns and as such there has been a moratorium on most of the loans.

"As soon as we roll out the ESP, we, in close consultation with the RMA (Royal Monetary Authority), will lift the loans moratorium and gradually lift the import moratorium and then provide the banks with support to enhance their liquidity levels," said the PM.

Lyonchhen said they we also look at the existing situation vis a vis loans including deferments and NPLs (Non-Performing Loans).

The ESP will also help roll out a whole range of subsidized loan services which means loans at a lower interest rate.

The PM emphasized that all this is being done in close consultation with RMA and they will continue to work closely with RMA on these matters.

"We need to make loans available through ESP via the normal banking channels once we lift the moratorium on loans. We expect the loans to resume through the normal banking services," said the PM how money would be pumped into the economy via the banks.

He said the ESP will be able to provide loans to help businesses to get back on their feet and to enhance and expand their services.

He said loans would be targeted towards generating employment and especially self-employment and for our youth.

There will be loans for farmers, special loans for women, youth, Cottage and Small Industries, Tourism and Creative Industries.

Lyonchhen stressed the target is to really stimulate the economy quickly and that is why loans will be there in all these various sectors.

The loans will not be a free for all bit there will be stringent and professional monitoring, including to ensure repayment.

"Obviously, these are loans and loans will be fully vetted and we will make sure that we study and are involved closely throughout the process from the design of the loans, proposals to disbursements to implementation of the activities and most importantly for recovering the loans. This is something that we all have to be very very mindful about," said Lyonchhen.

Lyonchhen said there will be different types of loans and they will have to wait to hear from the committee.

"My personal hope now is that there will be some loans that will be not be just collateral free but even subsidized. But for those loans there will be heavier oversight.

Why are collateral free loans are required? Because some people don't have collateral," said the PM

He said they should have access to loans but they should also be subject to much more stringent oversight.

Zhemgang unveils ambitious plans to boost tourism and economic prosperity

Dorji Choden/ *Zhemgang*

Sharing its border with five other districts namely Bumthang, Mongar, Pemagatshel, Sarpang and Trongsa, and an international border with the Assam in India, Zhemgang district boasts rich biodiversity spanning from subtropical to temperate climates. Despite its charm, the district has remained largely not noted to tourism, with only 346 tourists recorded in 2019 and the district with the highest poverty rate.

To convert Zhemgang district as the tourism hub of the country and decrease the poverty rate, the district has unveiled a comprehensive plan.

The region is also connected through the mangde chu, chamkhar chu, drangme chhu, and kuri gongri rivers, which combined becomes one of the biggest rivers, the manas river.

Zhemgang Dzongda Kesang Jigme, shared, "We want to reduce the poverty rate to 15% by 2029 and 5% by 2034. My vision is to make Zhemgang a Prosperous and Harmonious district. For that our focus area will be to create a vibrant community, enterprising people and high living standards."

The dzongkhag has come up with seven strategies to do that. Accelerating upscale, community-based ecotourism; encouraging smart farming and livestock processing; fostering an entrepreneurial culture and private sector development; improving public service delivery; expanding and upgrading rural-urban infrastructure; developing human capital through high-quality health and education services; and focusing on poverty since there are still economically vulnerable households that aren't receiving certain benefits. On the basis of all of these, the 13th Five Year Plan is being drafted.

"During the previous year, I conducted a survey on tour operators' perceptions. Their feedback indicated that inadequate infrastructure hinders their ability to promote the destination to tourists. The progress has been limited in the past, primarily due to accessibility issues. The region is far from international entry points and its isolation from major population centers has posed challenges. Additionally, we've faced constraints in tourism infrastructure, such as inadequate road amenities and accommodations. Furthermore, branding and promotion efforts have been hindered by a lack of reliable information on Zhemgang. These factors contribute to the low visitation rates experienced by the district," he further added.

Tashi, a 76-year-old resident of Dangkhar village, has witnessed the gradual transformation of forests into residential spaces throughout his lifetime in Zhemgang. He reflects on how the area used to be bustling with people, but now experiences a slow decline in population.

Sangay Wangdi, aged 75 and a native of Zhemgang, reminisces about his travels across Bhutan in earlier times. He shared, 'Zhemgang was among the first to have electricity, preceding even Haa, and our rooftop houses predated those in Dagana. Yet, despite these advancements, we felt neglected."

According to the Bhutan Living Standard Survey 2022, Zhemgang emerges as the poorest district, with a poverty rate of 41.4%.

In collaboration with the Department of Tourism (DOT), the district has invested in infrastructure development, filling a gap left by limited private sector investment.

Efforts have also been made to enhance the tourist experience, including the establishment of amenities like the Wangdigang roadside café and restroom in Tingtibi, as well as the construction of an Eco lodge in Berti.

The Wangdigang roadside café is being funded by the district and GEF which is currently run by nine youth from Zhemgang.

Sonam, a 21-year-old who works in the cafe, revealed, "On average, we welcome approximately 20 to 30 international tourists each month, along with domestic and regional visitors."

Collaborations with Denkar's Gateway and Yee Gateway have facilitated branding and promotional activities for the district. Initiatives aim to cater to diverse visitor demographics, including domestic, regional, and international tourists.

For domestic visitors, pilgrimage sites like Buli Tsho and the Dringbang hot stone bath which are popular are being promoted, with efforts to improve infrastructure to accommodate increasing demand. Panbang region offers a range of attractions for regional and international tourists, including river rafting, bird and butterfly watching, hiking trails, waterfalls, and local crafts.

The Panbang region currently welcomes around 900-1000 regional visitors per month.

A recent assessment conducted by the district found out that majority of the people depend on the cultivation of oranges and cardamom, while also revealing the potential for large-scale coffee production.

The dzongkhag shared that plans are underway to cultivate coffee and tea on 500 acres of farmland, aiming to bolster local incomes.

The Dzongda also outlined ambitious development plans, envisioning the establishment of three growth centers within the dzongkhag.

Zhemgang town is the administrative center, while Tingtibi is to become a commercial hub, catering to the Upper Kheng region. Additionally, Panbang is identified as another commercial center, serving the Lower Kheng region. By 2027, the goal is to commence coffee exports, contributing to the nation's GDP.

The establishment of the Gelephu Special Administrative Region (SAR) presents further opportunities for Zhemgang. Given its proximity to Gelephu, just a few hours' drive away, the district aims to take advantage of that to boost their tourism sector.

All these plans aim to bring in more tourists, help the local community attract more customers, and create job opportunities for the youths.

DEPARTMENT OF LAW AND ORDER (DLO)

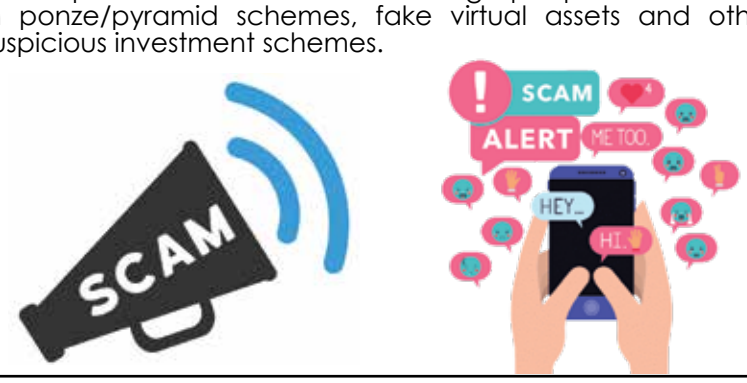
SCAM ALERT!!

It has come to the notice of the Department of Law and Order that some individuals, who are not registered as employment agent with the Department of Employment and Entrepreneurship, have again started to recruit Bhutanese employment seekers in the overseas. Please be informed that such a recruitment is illegal and liable for fine up to Nu.600,000/-

As per our experience, people who are recruited through such unscrupulous agents usually lands up being exploited in a foreign land leading to Trafficking in Person (TIP). TIP is a crime under Penal Code of Bhutan with imprisonment ranging from 3-5 years.

It is also noticed that scams of various types are on the rise, duping many Bhutanese people in the recent times. Many people have lost their hard earned money to these scammers.

In view of the above, the Department of Law and Order would like to request all Bhutanese to refrain from sharing bank details and OTP numbers to any one including those claiming to be from the bank or telecom company or government agency. The Department would also like to urge people not to invest in ponze/pyramid schemes, fake virtual assets and other suspicious investment schemes.



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Subscription cum Bill collection call 17801081 www.thebhutanese.bt BICMA Lic no. 303000002, Printer: Kuensel Corporation, Publisher: The Bhutanese Pvt. Ltd.